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ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

PHI 101: Introduction to Philosophy and Logic

Arguments, fallacies and the questions that do not go away

FACULTY PRIMER

Faculty Primer

Faculty of Arts
Philosophy | 100L

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

START HERE

Why this pack exists

This pack teaches the mechanics of argument first, then the classical divisions of philosophy. It includes validity and soundness, common fallacies, the problem of knowledge, ethics and African philosophy, plus a template for writing a philosophy answer that argues rather than narrates.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Distinguish validity from soundness.
- Identify and name common informal fallacies.
- Explain the main branches of philosophy with an example question each.
- Write a short philosophical argument with an objection and a reply.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Arguments, validity and soundness

A good argument is structurally valid and materially true.

- Premises support a conclusion; the conclusion is what is claimed.
- Validity concerns form: if premises are true, the conclusion must be.
- Soundness requires validity plus true premises.
- Deductive arguments guarantee; inductive arguments support with probability.
- Counterexample is the standard tool for testing a claim.
- Define your terms before you argue about them.

Fallacies you will meet

Naming the fallacy is half the correction.

- Ad hominem: attacking the person instead of the argument.
- Straw man: refuting a distorted version of the opponent's view.
- False dilemma: presenting two options when more exist.
- Appeal to authority or to popularity as a substitute for evidence.
- Begging the question: assuming what you set out to prove.
- Hasty generalisation and post hoc reasoning.

> **Charity principle**
> Argue against the strongest version of the opposing view. Defeating a weak version proves nothing.

Branches and African philosophy

Each branch has characteristic questions.

- Metaphysics: what exists, and what is a person?
- Epistemology: what is knowledge, and when is belief justified?
- Ethics: what makes an action right?
- Logic: what follows from what?
- Aesthetics: what is beauty and what is art?
- African philosophy: ethnophilosophy debates, ubuntu and communitarian ethics, sage philosophy, and the critique of a single 'African' position.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Can an argument be valid with false premises?

Answer: Yes. Validity concerns the form; soundness additionally requires true premises.

2. Name the fallacy of attacking a person rather than their argument.

Answer: Ad hominem.

3. What is begging the question?

Answer: An argument that assumes the truth of the conclusion it is supposed to establish.

4. Give one epistemological question.

Answer: What conditions must a true belief meet before it counts as knowledge?

5. What is the charity principle?

Answer: Interpreting an opponent's argument in its strongest reasonable form before criticising it.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Write five arguments in premise-conclusion form.
- [ ] Test each for validity and soundness.
- [ ] Learn ten fallacies with an example.
- [ ] Read one short Platonic dialogue.
- [ ] Summarise one debate in African philosophy.
- [ ] Draft an essay with an objection and a reply.
- [ ] Peer-review for unstated assumptions.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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